educated the masses in nationalist ideology, instilling a sense of the oneness of the Indian nation, its people and its territory and the injustice of a foreign nation ruling them for its own benefit. Outlining the course of the Swadeshi movement in Bengal, VOC and Siva exhorted the people to carry forward its ideology and programme in south India. References to the Russian revolution (of 1905) and national struggles across the world alarmed the government.

Speaking on 24 February, Siva said, 'If the coolies stood out for extra wages European mills in India would cease to exist. There are two ways of injuring the mill-owners; one was by doing mischief to machinery and the other was by going on strike.' While Siva wanted them to follow the second course, according to the police, VOC advocated the adoption of both courses. 'As a direct result of these speeches', workers of the Coral Mills went on strike from 27 February.

The Coral Mills strike was the crossing of the Rubicon. As we noted earlier, the mills were managed by A. & F. Harvey who were also the BI's Tuticorin Agents. Another element had now been added to the heady Swadeshi brew. VOC had launched a two-pronged attack on European economic interests in Tuticorin.

On 26 February, a day before the strike, VOC stated that he had been approached by some overenthusiastic supporters who intended to harm traders supporting BI, but that he had sternly dissuaded them.[14] The police and the local Europeans read this as a dog whistle: 'Chidambaram Pillai's words, while seemingly intended to show that Europeans need not apprehend any violence, are certainly understood in some quarters as if they were a direct incentive to violence.' The exclusively European Tuticorin Chamber of Commerce, had even passed a resolution expressing its fear about the 'seditious meetings held on the beach at Tuticorin and other parts of the town where threats are uttered against the life and property of European residents' and urged the sub-collector to intervene.[15]

Wynch, who had been biding his time, now swung into action. Ten days before the strike, Robert William D'Escourt Ashe, an Anglo-Irish ICS officer, was transferred from Cheranmadevi, a union in the Tirunelveli